

7

Motivation Concepts



Source: Darron Cummings/AP/Shutterstock

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this chapter, you should be able to:

- | | | | |
|------------|---|------------|---|
| 7-1 | Describe the three key elements of motivation. | 7-5 | Compare the process-based theories of motivation: expectancy theory, goal-setting theory, and self-efficacy theory. |
| 7-2 | Compare the classic theories of motivation. | 7-6 | Describe the forms of organizational justice, including distributive justice, procedural justice, informational justice, and interactional justice. |
| 7-3 | Contrast the content-based theories of motivation, including self-determination theory, regulatory-focus theory, and job engagement theory. | 7-7 | Describe how the contemporary theories of motivation complement one another. |
| 7-4 | Understand the differences between the context-based theories of motivation: reinforcement theory and social learning theory. | | |

Employability Skills Matrix (ESM)

	Myth or Science?	An Ethical Choice	Point/Counterpoint	Toward a Better World	Experiential Exercise	Ethical Dilemma	Case Incident
Critical Thinking & Creativity	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓
Communication	✓		✓	✓	✓		
Collaboration				✓	✓		
Self-Management					✓		✓
Social Responsibility	✓	✓	✓	✓		✓	
Leadership	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Career Management	✓						

ENGAGING EMPLOYEES AT SALESFORCE

Eighty-five percent of employees worldwide are actively disengaged or not engaged in their jobs. How do some companies maintain high job engagement levels while most other organizations struggle so much to do so? Salesforce is one such organization, included on Fortune's "100 Best Companies to Work For" list for the twelfth year in a row. Part of Salesforce's high workforce engagement levels may stem from its unique company culture and employee benefits. Salesforce differentiates itself from other organizations with exceptionally generous paid time off and leave policies, including fantastic child care assistance perks, commuter benefits, and career development (i.e., Salesforce will reimburse 100 percent of all college costs up to a limit for job-related courses).

The founders of Salesforce were intentional about developing a company culture that would directly foster job engagement and motivation. As a result, they prioritize employee well-being through dedicated mindfulness zones in offices and a Wellness Reimbursement Program. Employees receive \$100 each month to use toward their well-being in whichever way they please, from enrolling in fitness classes to seeking nutrition counseling. Beyond offering innovative perks, Salesforce can also sustain high job engagement by continuously monitoring engagement levels. All Salesforce employees complete engagement surveys twice a year, but Salesforce does not withhold employees' data. Employees are able to access the data from these surveys through a company app. The company is very transparent about its assessment practices. Through data sharing, employees are encouraged to take responsibility for the work environment and take a proactive role in shaping the culture.

The company also takes a somewhat unconventional approach by providing the same amount of transparency to its managers. All employees can access the data on their *manager's* engagement levels and team performance. The goal is not to publicly discredit the managers and their teams but rather to determine which management practices are working and which ones are not. This transparency helps the organization transform abstract strategies that encourage engagement and motivation into specific behaviors and policies. For example, explicitly recognizing that work-life balance prevents burnout is not enough. Companies need to help employees find this balance through their benefits, policies, practices, and management.

Salesforce offers training for teams exhibiting low engagement levels, including “Fearless Teaming,” which focuses on cultivating “psychological safety” or an environment in which people feel comfortable taking risks. Jody Kohner, senior vice president of employee engagement at Salesforce, suggests that employees are empowered to do their best work when they feel comfortable taking risks. Employees and managers are also empowered to maximize the fit between employees and their teams. For instance, Salesforce launched an internal mobility program that empowers employees to switch teams if they do not feel like they fit with their current team. The organization’s investment in these initiatives has paid off as it can retain employees for longer and continue to be a successful, profitable company.¹

Motivation is a powerful force. It can drive employees through encouragement and reward to accomplish challenging goals. However, it can also prompt employees to cheat when they experience injustice or are threatened by unattainable goals. Navigating and predicting these forces becomes a challenge to both workers and managers. Despite the challenges, knowing more about motivation theories can help increase an understanding of how motivation may operate and how employees become motivated.

Millions of people each year spend money in the hopes that they will become more “motivated.” In the United States alone, self-improvement and motivational services is an \$11 billion market that is expected to grow 5.1 percent on average until 2027.² Motivation is also one of the most frequently researched topics in organizational behavior (OB),³ and full-time OB practitioners (e.g., industrial-organizational psychologists, management consultants, human resource professionals) list it as one of the top most-needed areas for continued research in the field.⁴ Beyond interest in the topic, people do appear to be generally unmotivated at least for a part of the workweek. In one survey, 69 percent of workers reported wasting time at work every day, and nearly a quarter said they waste between thirty and sixty minutes each day. How? Usually by surfing the Internet (checking the news and visiting social network sites) and chatting with coworkers.⁵ Although times change, the problem of motivating a workforce stays the same.

In this chapter, we will review the basics of motivation, assess motivation theories, and provide an integrative model that fits these theories together. In the next chapter, we will apply what we know about motivation to solve motivation problems in the workplace.

Motivation Defined

The same student who struggles to dedicate time to read an assigned book for class may devour a *New York Times* best seller in a day. The difference lies in levels of motivation.

We define **motivation** as the processes that account for an individual's *intensity*, *direction*, and *persistence* of effort toward attaining a goal.⁶ While general motivation is concerned with effort toward *any* goal, we will narrow the focus to *organizational* goals. Levels of motivation can vary from moment to moment and can also be meaningful individual differences (see the chapter on personality and individual differences). In other words, motivation can take form as both a personality trait and a temporary state.

Intensity describes how hard a person tries. This is the element most of us focus on when we talk about motivation. However, high intensity is unlikely to lead to favorable job performance outcomes unless the effort is channeled in a *direction* that benefits the organization. Effort directed toward and consistent with the organization's goals is the kind of effort organizations should be seeking to improve. Finally, motivation has a *persistence* dimension. This measures how long a person can maintain effort. Motivated individuals work intensely on an appropriate task long enough to achieve their goals.

Many classic and contemporary theories of motivation focus on employee needs as goals to attain and describe whether their organizations, jobs, and work fulfill those needs. Other theories portray goals as means toward organizational ends, such as the fulfillment of job duties and responsibilities. Although we discuss remote work to a greater extent in the next chapter on motivation applications, the issues facing remote workers reflect both perspectives. As shown in the OB Poll,

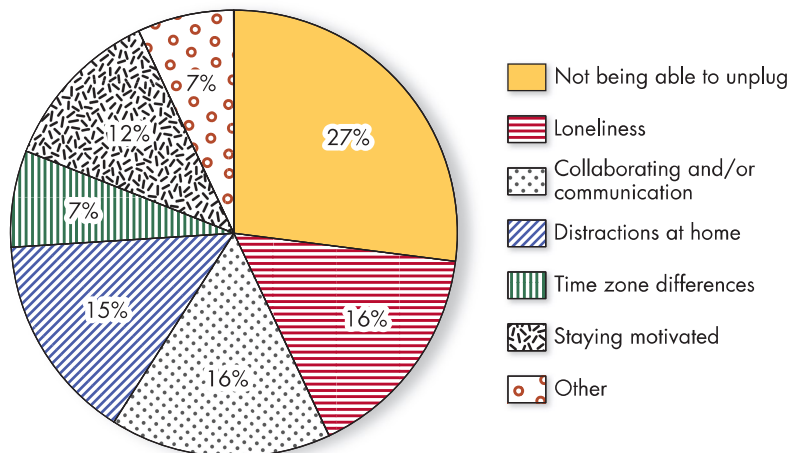
7-1 Describe the three key elements of motivation.

motivation The processes that account for an individual's intensity, direction, and persistence of effort toward attaining a goal.

OB POLL

Is a Lack of Motivation the Biggest Issue Remote Workers Face?

What is your biggest struggle with working remotely?



Source: Based on "The 2021 State of Remote Work," Buffer, January 4, 2021, <https://buffer.com/2021-state-of-remote-work>

remote workers' biggest struggles include the difficulty of fulfilling people's need to interact with other people as well as obstacles that thwart goal attainment, like household distractions and time zone differences. In the next section, we describe more classic theories of motivation, which portray motivation as a process involving people's psychological needs and the extent to which work meets or neglects those needs.

Classic Theories of Motivation

7-2 Compare the classic theories of motivation.

Three theories of employee motivation formulated during the 1950s are considered to be classics in the study of motivation. They represent a foundation of motivation theory, with many practicing managers still using their terminology. However, now they are of questionable validity (as we will discuss), and as evidence-based OB practitioners, we should carefully and cautiously consider their use when compared with more contemporary theories, discussed later in this chapter.

Hierarchy of Needs Theory

hierarchy of needs Abraham Maslow's hierarchy of five needs—physiological, safety, social, esteem, and self-actualization.

The best-known theory of motivation is Abraham Maslow's **hierarchy of needs**,⁷ which hypothesizes that within every human being there is a hierarchy of five needs humans are motivated to meet. A sixth need has been proposed for a highest level—intrinsic values—which is said to have originated from Maslow, but it has not gained widespread acceptance.⁸ The original five needs are:

1. **Physiological.** Hunger, thirst, shelter, and other bodily needs.
2. **Safety.** Security and protection from physical and emotional harm.
3. **Social-belongingness (originally love).** Affection, love, belongingness, acceptance, and friendship.
4. **Esteem.** Internal factors such as self-respect, autonomy, and achievement as well as external factors such as status, recognition, and attention.
5. **Self-actualization.** Drive to become what we can become; includes growth, achieving our potential, and self-fulfillment.

According to many interpretations of Maslow's work,⁹ as each need becomes well satisfied, the next one becomes dominant. This has led to the popularized depiction of the hierarchy as a pyramid or a ladder. Maslow himself, however, merely outlined the need categories and suggested that some may take precedence depending upon the situation.¹⁰ We depict the hierarchy as a pyramid in Exhibit 7-1 because this is its best-known presentation, but it is important to recognize that Maslow did not depict the hierarchy of needs in this way. Maslow's theory has broadly received long-standing recognition, particularly among practicing managers. Perhaps the broad recognition is because it is intuitively logical and easy to understand, especially in its ladder or pyramid form. Unfortunately, however, most research does not support its validity, and it has not been frequently researched since the 1960s.¹¹ Nonetheless, it is thus important to be aware of the prevailing public acceptance of the hierarchy when discussing motivation but also to recognize that psychological needs paint an incomplete portrait of motivation in the workplace.

Two-Factor Theory

Believing an individual's relationship to work is basic and that the attitude toward work can determine success or failure, psychologist Frederick Herzberg wondered, "What do people want from their jobs?" He asked people to describe, in detail, situations in which they felt exceptionally *good* or *bad* about their jobs.

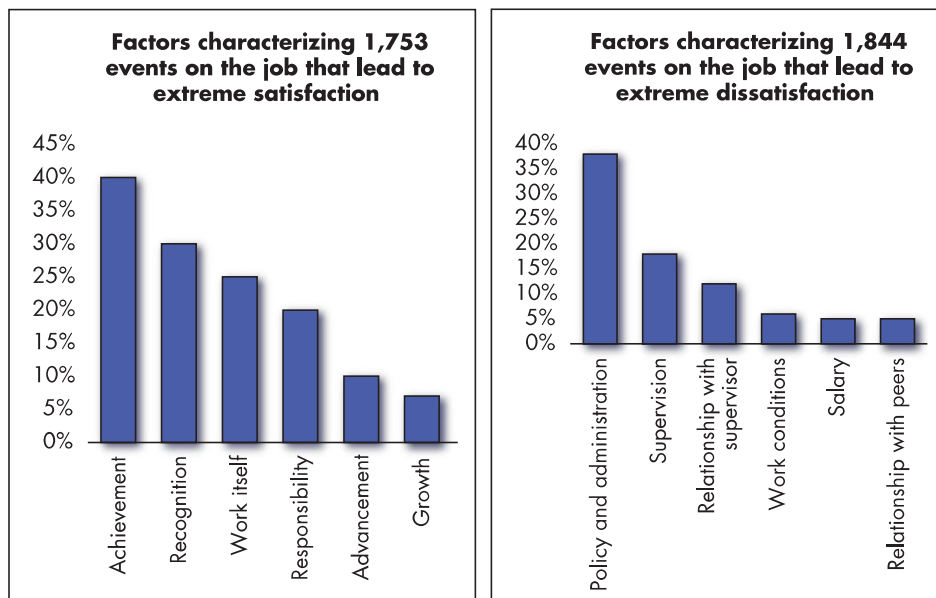
Exhibit 7-1**Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs**

Source: Based on H. Skelsey, "Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs—the Sixth Level," *Psychologist* (2014): 982–83.

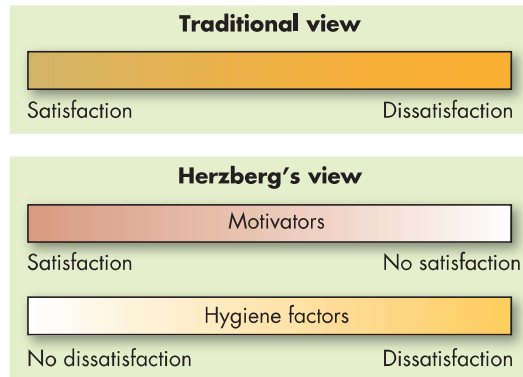
The responses differed significantly and led Herzberg to his **two-factor theory** (also called *motivation-hygiene theory*, but this term is not used much today).¹² Two-factor theory is inherently tied to job satisfaction (see the chapter on job attitudes) and expresses motivation in terms of intrinsic and extrinsic factors that impact job satisfaction.

Under two-factor theory, the factors that lead to job satisfaction are separate and distinct from those that lead to job dissatisfaction. As shown in Exhibit 7-2, intrinsic factors such as advancement, recognition, responsibility, and achievement seem related to job satisfaction. Respondents who felt good about their work tended to attribute these factors to their situations, while dissatisfied respondents tended to cite extrinsic factors, such as supervision, pay, company policies, and work conditions.

two-factor theory A theory that relates intrinsic factors to job satisfaction and associates extrinsic factors with dissatisfaction. Also called motivation-hygiene theory.

Exhibit 7-2**Comparison of Satisfiers and Dissatisfiers**

Source: Based on Harvard Business Review, "Comparison of Satisfiers and Dissatisfiers," An exhibit from *One More Time: How Do You Motivate Employees?* by Frederick Herzberg, January 2003. Copyright © 2003 by the Harvard Business School Publishing Corporation. All rights reserved.

Exhibit 7-3**Contrasting View of Satisfaction and Dissatisfaction**

To Herzberg, the data suggest that the opposite of satisfaction is not dissatisfaction, as was traditionally believed (see Exhibit 7-3). Removing dissatisfying characteristics from a job does not necessarily make the job satisfying; managers would be placating rather than motivating employees. Herzberg proposed a dual continuum: The opposite of “satisfaction” is “no satisfaction,” and the opposite of “dissatisfaction” is “no dissatisfaction.”

Conditions such as quality of supervision, pay, company policies, physical work conditions, relationships with others, and job security are **hygiene factors**. When they are adequate, people will not be dissatisfied; neither will they be satisfied. If we want to *motivate* people on their jobs, we should emphasize factors associated with the work itself or with outcomes directly derived from it, such as promotional opportunities, personal growth opportunities, recognition, responsibility, and achievement. These are the characteristics people find intrinsically rewarding.

The two-factor theory has not been well supported in research. Criticisms center on Herzberg's original methodology and his assumptions, such as how the participants may be biased in thinking back to times when they felt good or bad about their jobs.¹³ Furthermore, if hygiene and motivational factors are equally important to a person, both should be capable of motivating. Regardless of the criticisms, Herzberg's theory has been quite influential and has been used in many studies.¹⁴ Most managers worldwide are familiar with its recommendations.

McClelland's Theory of Needs

Imagine that you are a sales manager in a well-known mountaineer outfitting company, reviewing the bonus memo you received earlier in the day. If you meet the easier, level 1 sales goal, you will get a \$2,000 bonus. If you meet the level 2 sales goal (which only 80 percent of the people who attempt actually attain), you will get a \$4,000 bonus. Level 3 pays \$8,000, but only half the people who try can attain it. Finally, Level 4 pays \$32,000, but it is almost impossible to achieve. Which would you try for? If you selected level 3, you are likely a high achiever.

McClelland's theory of needs, unlike Maslow's hierarchy, suggests that needs are more like motivating factors than prerequisites for survival.¹⁵ In McClelland and colleagues' theory, there are three primary needs:

- **Need for achievement (nAch)** is the need to excel or achieve to a set of standards.

hygiene factors Factors—such as company policy and administration, supervision, and salary—that, when adequate in a job, placate workers and limit job dissatisfaction.

McClelland's theory of needs A theory that achievement, power, and affiliation are three important needs that help explain motivation.

need for achievement (nAch) The need to excel or achieve to a set of standards.

- **Need for power (nPow)** is the need to make others behave in a way they would not have otherwise.
- **Need for affiliation (nAff)** is the need to establish friendly and close interpersonal relationships.

need for power (nPow) The need to make others behave in a way in which they would not have behaved otherwise.

need for affiliation (nAff) The need to establish friendly and close interpersonal relationships.

McClelland and subsequent researchers focused most of their attention on nAch.¹⁶ In general, high achievers perform best when they perceive their probability of success as 0.5—that is, a fifty-fifty chance. Similarly, they dislike low odds (high probability of success) because then there is no challenge to their skills. Based on prior nAch research, we can predict some relationships between nAch and job performance. First, when employees have a high level of nAch, they tend to exhibit more positive moods and be more interested in the task at hand.¹⁷ Second, employees high on nAch tend to perform very well in high-stakes conditions on the job, like work walkthroughs or sales encounters.¹⁸

The other needs within the theory have also been empirically supported. First, the nPow concept has research support, but it may be more familiar to people in broad terms than in relation to the original definition.¹⁹ We will discuss power much more in the chapter on power and politics. Second, the nAff concept is also well established and accepted in research—for example, one study of 145 teams suggests that groups composed of employees with a high nAff tend to perform the best, exhibit the most open communication, and experience the least amount of conflict (compared with the other needs).²⁰ Additional research suggests that our individual differences (discussed in the chapter on personality and individual differences) may affect whether we can satisfy these needs. For example, a high degree of neuroticism can prevent one from fulfilling the nAff, whereas agreeableness supports fulfillment of this need; interestingly, extroversion had no significant effect.²¹ Furthermore, some evidence suggests that women may be more likely to have more nAff needs than men.²²

The degree to which we have each of the three needs is difficult to measure, and therefore the theory is difficult to put into practice. A behavior may be directed at satisfying many different needs, and many different behaviors may be directed at satisfying one given need, making needs difficult to isolate and examine.²³ Therefore, the concepts are helpful, but they are not often used objectively.

Contemporary Theories: A Primer

Although these three classic theories are quite common, they do not represent the universe of influential motivation theories in management. In fact, a number of distinct motivation theories have made a substantial contribution, helping illuminate the nature of motivation in organizations. Some of these theories may also be considered “classics” (e.g., behaviorism, expectancy theory), while others may be relatively more modern. Regardless, these theories share the fact that they are still the focus of (mostly supportive) research and practice in OB to this day, which makes them “contemporary” theories in our view. These “contemporary theories” represent the latest thinking in explaining employee motivation. This does not mean they are unquestionably right, however.

To help categorize these motivation theories, it might be helpful to break down the core components of these theories. Researchers, for instance, have classified motivation theories into three categories: (a) *content*, (b), *context*, and (c) *processes*.²⁴ The *content* category is primarily concerned with fundamental motives and individual differences in motivation states common to all people. This category includes self-determination theory, regulatory-focus theory, and job engagement theory. The *context* category involves sources of motivation that

stem from the contexts people find themselves in. For instance, the theories of reinforcement, behaviorism, and social learning (which some would also consider to be classics) would fit in here. Next, the *process* category involves the direct motivation theories that focus on the process of choosing and striving toward goals. This includes expectancy, goal-setting, and self-efficacy theories. Although some may correctly suggest that justice and organizational justice are fundamental motives and would fit into the “content” category, given their importance to ethics in organizations, we close our discussion of motivation theories by devoting an entire section to them.

Contemporary Theories of Motivation: Content-Based

7-3 Contrast the content-based theories of motivation, including self-determination theory, regulatory-focus theory, and job engagement theory.

self-determination theory A meta-theory of motivation at work that is concerned with autonomy, intrinsic motivation, extrinsic motivation, and the satisfaction of psychological work needs.

Self-Determination Theory

Think of what led you to choose your college major. Did you feel like you had a choice in the matter? Did you feel free to explore and choose a major that was right for you? Were others pressuring you to choose a major? Did you feel like you had the support of your parents, friends, and teachers? These questions are all relevant to a self-determination theory (SDT) perspective on motivation.²⁵

Self-determination theory (SDT) proposes that employees’ well-being and performance are influenced by the nature of their motivation for certain job activities.²⁶ For instance, a sense of choice over what they do, how motivating the task is in and of itself, how rewards influence motivation, and how work satisfies psychological needs are all fundamental components of SDT. The theory is actually a *meta-theory* (or a collection of related theories behind a common theme) and is widely used in psychology, management, education, and medical research. A key tenant of SDT is that motivation can be either *autonomous* (e.g., freely chosen) or *controlled* (e.g., as a result of others’ pressure or direction). Supporting SDT, data from approximately 40,000 schoolteachers showed that autonomous motivation had pronounced effects on teacher well-being, stress, and teaching quality.²⁷

Cognitive Evaluation Theory “It’s strange,” said Jordan. “I started work at the Humane Society as a volunteer. I put in fifteen hours a week helping people adopt pets. I loved coming to work. But then, three months ago, they hired me full-time at \$11 an hour. I am doing the same work I did before. But I’m not finding it as much fun.” Does Jordan’s reaction seem counterintuitive?

One explanation can be found in **cognitive evaluation theory (CET)**, a sub-theory that suggests that extrinsic rewards (e.g., pay) reduce people’s intrinsic interest in a task.²⁸ When people are paid for work, it feels less like something they *want* to do and more like something they *must* do. For example, if a computer programmer values writing code out of a love for solving problems, a bonus for writing a certain number of lines of code every day could feel coercive, and the programmer’s intrinsic motivation could suffer.

CET suggests that some caution in the use of extrinsic rewards to motivate is wise and that pursuing goals from intrinsic motives (such as a strong interest in the work itself) is better for sustaining motivation. Similarly, CET suggests that providing extrinsic incentives may, in many cases, undermine intrinsic motivation. In support, research confirms that intrinsic motivation contributes to the quality of work, while incentives contribute to the quantity of work. The effects of intrinsic motivation may be weaker when incentives are directly tied to performance (such as a monetary bonus for each call made in a call center).²⁹

cognitive evaluation theory A sub-theory of self-determination theory in which extrinsic rewards for behavior tend to decrease the overall level of motivation if the rewards are seen as controlling or reduce their sense of competence.

Self-Concordance Theory Another aspect of self-determination theory is **self-concordance theory**, which considers how strongly people's reasons for pursuing goals are consistent with their interests and core values.³⁰ People who pursue work goals that align with their interests and values are more satisfied with their jobs, feel they fit into their organizations better, and may perform better.³¹ Across cultures, if individuals pursue goals because of intrinsic interest, they are more likely to attain goals, are happier when they do so, and are happy even if they are unable to attain them.³² Why? Because they feel like they are more competent at accomplishing the goal and feel like they fit better with their organization. When people do not enjoy their work for intrinsic reasons, those who work because they feel obligated to do so can still perform acceptably, though they experience higher levels of strain.³³ On the other hand, even gig workers who work short-term contracts (defined explicitly by rewards) are likely to be motivated if their psychological needs, values, and interests are met by their job.³⁴ Self-concordance has recently been extended toward research on social responsibility. If your interests in sustainability align with your organization's, you may be more likely to engage in more socially responsible behaviors.³⁵

self-concordance The degree to which people's reasons for pursuing goals are consistent with their interests and core values.

Basic Psychological Needs Similar to Maslow's and McClelland's theories, discussed in the prior section, SDT also suggests that there are several basic psychological needs that affect work motivation. When they are satisfied, we tend to be more motivated; when they are frustrated, we tend to be less motivated. *Need for relatedness* is very similar to nAff, discussed in the prior section. However, **need for autonomy** and **need for competence** are two newer needs that correspond with the need to feel in control and autonomous at work and the need to feel like we are good at what we do and proud of it.³⁷ SDT proposes that, in addition to being driven by a need for autonomy, people seek ways to achieve competence and make positive connections with others. Of all the three needs, however, the need for autonomy is the most important for attitudinal and affective

need for autonomy The need to feel in control and autonomous at work.

need for competence The need to feel like we are good at what we do or proud of it.

Work Has to Be Purposeful to Be Motivating

Describing the impact employees' work has on the world has become a familiar strategy that organizations use to inspire employees. For example, Amazon tells employees they are building the future, and Microsoft describes how employees empower individuals and organizations around the world to achieve more. The belief is that if workers view their job as purposeful, organizations can avert demotivation.

However, only a small percentage of employees worldwide, regardless of the company they belong to, appear to be motivated and engaged. While employees who find work meaningful experience significantly higher job satisfaction, a fixation on purpose

could have unintended consequences. Although workplaces from IKEA to Microsoft promise meaningful work with a greater purpose, employees' tasks may be routine and disconnected from the inspirational purpose organizations are promising. One survey of seven hundred employees across twenty-two industries demonstrates this disconnect. In this study, all but one employee were able to very quickly identify a trivial or meaningless task that they were required to do regularly for their job. In other words, most employees seem to recognize that their jobs have some tasks that seem mundane or trivial. When their supposed impact and the reality do not match up, employees are more likely to reflect on their work's lack

of impact than their actual impact. The result is lower levels of meaning, enjoyment, and motivation.

However, just because some jobs require employees to do more of these routine tasks does not mean these employees have to be any less motivated or engaged. One promising intervention is "superordinate framing." Employees can use this framing tool to think about how seemingly unimportant tasks work to achieve a greater purpose. If organizations invest in helping employees find meaning and purpose in even the most mundane tasks, the payoff could be considerable. Such an intervention may make employees less likely to quit their jobs, more satisfied with their work, and potentially more productive.³⁶

Myth or Science?

outcomes, whereas the need for competence appears to be most important for predicting performance.³⁸ Also, when using extrinsic rewards, need satisfaction matters less for performance when the rewards are directly salient and clear.³⁹

What does all this mean? Managers need to design jobs so that they are motivating, provide recognition, and support employee growth and development. These actions are especially critical for new employee onboarding, as many employees are still deciding whether the job is a good fit for them.⁴⁰ Employees who feel autonomous and free in what they choose to do are likely to be more motivated by their work and committed to their employers. Furthermore, employees can satisfy many of these needs through helping others,⁴¹ but do not *pressure* them to help each other!⁴² As Walmart leadership coach Lucy Duncan suggests about Walmart associates, if you take the time to incorporate SDT in your workplace, “you will be blown away with associate satisfaction.”⁴³

Regulatory Focus Theory

People differ in the way they regulate their thoughts and behaviors during goal pursuit.⁴⁴ Generally, people fall into one of two categories, or *regulatory foci*, though they could belong to both. Those with a **promotion focus** strive for advancement and accomplishment and approach conditions that move them closer toward desired goals. Those with a **prevention focus** strive to fulfill duties and obligations and avoid conditions that pull them away from desired goals. People do not necessarily stick with one strategy permanently, however.⁴⁵ It is just as accurate to think of promotion and prevention as potential motivational states workers experience: Sometimes they are more focused on striving for accomplishment, and other times they are more focused on avoiding failure. In general, it is best when employees’ regulatory “foci” fit with the demands of the environment—sometimes promotion is preferable, and sometimes prevention is preferable.⁴⁶ For instance, messages that fit with citizens’ regulatory foci helped encourage compliance of safety behaviors during COVID-19: Promotion-focused people responded better to “what you can do to help you stay healthy,” while prevention-focused people responded better to “what you can do to keep America safe.”⁴⁷

Although you would be right in noting that both strategies are in the service of goal accomplishment, the way they get there is quite different. As an example, consider studying for an exam. You could engage in promotion-focused activities such as reading class materials, or you could engage in prevention-focused activities such as refraining from doing things that would get in the way of studying, such as playing video games.

You may ask, “Which is the better strategy?” Well, the answer depends on the outcome you are striving for. A promotion (but not a prevention) focus is related to higher levels of task performance, citizenship behavior, and innovation; a prevention (but not a promotion) focus is related to safety performance. Ideally, it is probably best to be both promotion- *and* prevention-oriented, depending upon the situation.⁴⁸ Employees and managers should set achievable goals, remove distractions, and provide structure for these individuals.⁴⁹ The role of the manager is particularly important because they set the tone for the rest of the employees; regulatory focus is contagious and can “trickle down” through the ranks.⁵⁰ Furthermore, research suggests that if an individuals’ focus matches their supervisor’s, they will report higher relationship quality, be more committed to the relationship, and engage in more organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs) directed at their supervisor to maintain the relationship.⁵¹

Job Engagement Theory

When Addison reports to work as a hospital nurse, it seems that everything else melts away. Addison becomes completely absorbed in the job: All emotions,

promotion focus A self-regulation strategy that involves striving for goals through advancement and accomplishment.

prevention focus A self-regulation strategy that involves striving for goals by fulfilling duties and obligations and avoiding failure.

thoughts, and behavior are all directed toward patient care. In fact, Addison can get caught up in work to the point of not even being aware of the time. As a result of this state, Addison is more effective in providing patient care and feels uplifted by the work.

Addison has a high level of **job engagement**, the investment of an employee's physical, cognitive, and emotional energies into job performance.⁵² Many also portray job/work engagement as a motivational state characterized by vigorous completion of the work, dedication to the task, and complete absorption in what one is doing,⁵³ although more research appears to support the “energy-investment” state referenced in this text's definition.⁵⁴ If this term seems familiar to you, you are correct—*employee engagement* was a term introduced in the chapter on job attitudes. Why are we introducing it again here? OB scholars actually view engagement in two different ways:⁵⁵ One is as a job attitude, a level of enthusiasm people have toward their work. The other is as a motivational state.

Practicing managers and scholars have become interested in facilitating job engagement, given that disengaged employees cost U.S. businesses up to \$550 billion annually in lost productivity.⁵⁶ Job engagement appears to matter for organizations and has been found to predict higher levels of task performance and citizenship behavior.⁵⁷ However, as described in the chapter on job attitudes, the construct is partially redundant with job attitudes like organizational commitment.⁵⁸

What makes people more likely to be engaged in their jobs? One review of over 40,000 employees suggests that apart from a proactive personality, conscientiousness, and extroversion, one key trait predicts job engagement: employees' tendencies to experience positive moods and emotions (e.g., positive affectivity; see the chapter on emotions and mood).⁵⁹ Context factors also play a role. For example, job characteristics and access to sufficient resources to work effectively, person–organization value fit, and inspirational leadership all affect job engagement as well.⁶⁰

job engagement The investment of an employee's physical, cognitive, and emotional energies into job performance.

Contemporary Theories of Motivation: Context-Based

The contemporary content theories of motivation are similar to the classical theories discussed earlier as they primarily concern the fundamental, universal “truths” of motivation that exist across people. They cover content like psychological needs and individual differences in people's motivation. However, they are far from the only noteworthy OB theories on the subject. For instance, a number of other classic theories that emphasize the role of the context or environment on motivation are still used and supported to this day.

7-4 Understand the differences between the context-based theories of motivation: reinforcement theory and social learning theory.

Reinforcement Theory

Reinforcement theory argues that reinforcement conditions behavior.⁶¹ Reinforcement theory is *behaviorist*, meaning that it portrays behavior as caused by the context or environment. You need not be concerned, behaviorists would argue, with internal cognitive events (such as the psychological aspects of autonomy, regulatory focus, or job engagement or the process-based theories to come). Instead, what controls behavior are reinforcers—any consequences that, when they immediately follow responses, increase the probability that the behavior will be repeated. For example, when you are given a compliment for doing something at work, you might be more likely to do it again.

Reinforcement theory ignores the inner state of the individual and concentrates solely on what happens when the individual acts. Although it is not strictly

reinforcement theory A theory suggesting that behavior is a function of its consequences.

a motivation theory, it does provide a powerful means of analyzing what controls behavior, and therefore we typically do consider reinforcement when we think about motivation in OB. It is also important to note that strict adherence to reinforcement and behaviorism is not recommended because, clearly, people have rich psychological worlds that impact their motivations and behavior. However, there is a great deal of truth to be found in behaviorist approaches concerning the roles of reinforcement and conditioning on human behavior.

Operant Conditioning/Behaviorism and Reinforcement *Operant conditioning* suggests that people *learn* to behave in a certain way to either get something they want or avoid something they do not want. Reinforcement strengthens a behavior and increases the likelihood it will be repeated. Operant conditioning was part of B. F. Skinner's broader concept of **behaviorism**, which argues that behavior follows stimuli in a relatively unthinking manner. Skinner's form of radical behaviorism rejects feelings, thoughts, and other states of mind as causes of behavior. In short, people learn to associate stimulus and response, but their conscious awareness of this association is irrelevant.⁶² For instance, a commissioned salesperson wanting to earn a sizable income finds doing so is contingent on generating high sales, so the salesperson sells as much as possible. Skinner demonstrated that people will likely engage in desired behaviors if they are positively reinforced for doing so; rewards are most effective if they immediately follow the desired response; and behavior that is not rewarded or is punished is less likely to be repeated.

Of course, the linkage can also teach individuals to engage in behaviors that work against the best interests of the organization. Assume your supervisor says that if you work overtime during the next three-week busy season, you will be compensated for it at your next performance appraisal. However, when performance appraisal time comes, you are given no positive reinforcement for your overtime work. The next time your boss asks you to work overtime, what will you do? You will probably decline! Moreover, many of the predictions of the other theories we have discussed so far are at odds with reinforcement theory. Although reinforcement theory would predict that rewards pretty much *always* reinforce behavior, you may recall that cognitive evaluation theory suggests that sometimes rewards can *undermine* behavior by putting a damper on intrinsic motivation.

Social Learning Theory

Individuals can learn by being told or by observing what happens to other people as well as through direct experience. Much of what we have learned comes from watching models—coworkers, supervisors, customers, and so forth. The view that we can learn through both observation and direct experience is called **social learning theory**.⁶⁴

Social learning theory, like reinforcement theory, assumes behavior is a function of consequences—but it also clarifies the effects of observation and perception in motivation. People respond to the way they perceive and define consequences, not to the objective consequences themselves. As an essential component of social learning theory, people learn from and “model” their behavior from other people. More specifically, they pay attention to what others are doing, commit and retain what they do to memory, and reproduce the behaviors from memory. Moreover, we are more likely to repeat behaviors in the future if they are also reinforced by the model (e.g., positive feedback from a coach or trainer).

Researchers in organizations have become particularly interested in how supervisors model behavior to their employees and whether the employees actually learn and apply what they observe on the job. This is especially

behaviorism A theory stating that behavior follows stimuli in a relatively unthinking manner.

social learning theory The view that we can learn through both observation and direct experience.

An Ethical Choice

Motivated by Big Brother

Technology is a great thing. The Internet provides us with instant access to an abundance of information, and smartphones allow us to stay connected with others through e-mail, texting, and tweeting. Yet that ease of connectivity has also given employees the sinking feeling they are being watched—and they are right. But is tracking employees ethical?

Some companies are using technology to track their employees' activities, and some of this tracking is done in the name of science. For example, Bank of America Corp. wanted to learn whether face-to-face interaction made a difference to the productivity of its call center teams, so it asked around a hundred workers to wear badges for a few weeks that tracked their whereabouts.

Discovering that the most productive workers interacted most frequently with others, the company scheduled work breaks for groups rather than individually. This is a nice outcome, but how did the monitoring affect the behavior and motivation of the workers?

Other companies track employees to ensure that they are hard at work, which risks completely demotivating some. Accurate Biometrics, for example, uses computer monitoring to oversee its telecommuters. Says Timothy Daniels, VP of operations, looking at websites his employees have visited “enables us to keep a watchful eye without being over-invasive.” Currently, around 70 percent of organizations monitor their employees.

Practically speaking, managers may not want to adopt technologies that

demotivate their employees through micromanagement. Perhaps more important, though, how can they use monitoring technology ethically in workplace applications? First and foremost, employees should be informed that their activities will be tracked. Second, the purpose of tracking should be made clear to employees. Are workers being monitored to learn something that might help them and the organization as a whole? Or are they being monitored to ensure that they never slack off? Finally, it should be made clear which behaviors are inappropriate. Taking a legitimate work break is different from spending hours on a social networking site. These guidelines should increase the likelihood that monitoring programs are accepted and perceived to be fair.⁶³

true concerning leader behaviors like servant leadership (see the chapter on leadership).⁶⁵ However, the *way in which work is completed* is also a hot topic: Research has demonstrated that employees are motivated to act pragmatically, autonomously, and even unethically if they observe their supervisors acting that way.⁶⁶ Furthermore, many might assume that team members would “pick up the slack” if their leader defaults toward doing nothing. However, this does not appear to be the case: Team members are less likely to fill the leadership gap in teams when the supervisors are not fulfilling their duties and instead “slack off” themselves.⁶⁷

Contemporary Theories of Motivation: Process-Based

Expectancy Theory

One of the most widely accepted explanations of motivation is Victor Vroom's **expectancy theory**.⁶⁸ Although it has critics, most evidence supports the theory.⁶⁹ Expectancy theory argues that the strength of our tendency to act a certain way depends on the strength of our expectation of a given outcome and its attractiveness. In practical terms, employees will be motivated to exert a high level of effort when they believe that it will lead to a good performance appraisal, that a good appraisal will lead to organizational rewards such as salary increases and/or intrinsic rewards, and that these rewards will satisfy their personal goals. Therefore, the theory focuses on three relationships (see Exhibit 7-4) that, in many ways, establish a common language to describe the motivational process:

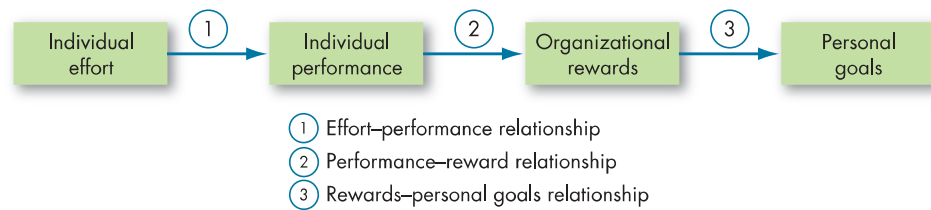
7-5 Compare the process-based theories of motivation: expectancy theory, goal-setting theory, and self-efficacy theory.

expectancy theory A theory that suggests that the strength of a tendency to act in a certain way depends on the strength of an expectation that the act will be followed by a given outcome and on the attractiveness of that outcome to the individual.

1. **Expectancy: the effort–performance relationship.** The degree to which the individual believes exerting a given amount of effort will lead to performance.
2. **Instrumentality: the performance–reward relationship.** The degree to which the individual believes performing at a particular level will lead to the attainment of a desired outcome.
3. **Valence: the rewards–personal goals relationship.** The degree to which organizational rewards satisfy an individual’s personal goals or needs and the attractiveness of those potential rewards for the individual.

Expectancy theory helps explain why a lot of workers are not motivated on their jobs and do only the minimum necessary to get by. It can also explain employees’ efforts toward goal accomplishment. For example, let us consider a work contest. The prize? An employee of the month parking spot. Some may really want this; others could not care less (valence). Maybe if the business shares a parking lot with Trader Joe’s (and is thus frequently crowded), this spot would be more coveted. Next, what is the contest like? Let us say it is whoever solicits the most donations to the company charity

Exhibit 7-4 Expectancy Theory



The performance–reward relationship is strong at Mary Kay Cosmetics, which offers a rewards and recognition program based on the achievement of personal goals set by each salesperson. The associates shown here in China pose before a pink sedan, one of many rewards that motivate Mary Kay’s independent sales force.

Source: China Photos/Getty Images

